

COLLECTED WRITINGS · 2026

Product, Leadership, & *the Work That Matters*

Essays on building products, navigating dysfunction,
and finding environments where talented people can
do what you hired them to do.

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The Shortcut is a Mirage

On software, maturity, and the work that matters

Software development is not an automatable task. It requires accountability — like anything with value.

When someone pitches automating a \$140K salary, of course companies pay attention. But there's a reason that job pays well. In SaaS, the software IS the product.

My personal thesis on maturity comes down to two things: holding contradictions instead of thinking in binaries, and accepting that there is no shortcut.

I can build a SPA in an hour with Claude. But the demo isn't the product. What you call a shortcut today is tech debt tomorrow.

Humans create the agents. Humans decide what to measure and how. Data is human-made. AI is human-made.

The shortcut is a mirage.

Study Video Games

The best product case studies are hiding in plain sight

Want to get better at product? Study video games.

Not because it's trendy — because the entire history of the industry is documented, recent enough to trace in real time, and built by teams solving the exact same problems we all face: scope creep, platform shifts, user obsession vs. business reality.

The development cycles, the platform wars, the products that defined entire generations of users — it's all there.

You can learn big-P Product from studying any industry. But few industries let you watch the full arc — from garage experiment to global platform — with this much transparency.

ESSAY 02 OF 10

Process Isn't the Enemy of Speed. Chaos Is.

What intake systems reveal about product culture

Show me how work enters your product org and I'll tell you if it actually works.

Not the roadmap. Not the retros. Not the tools.

How does a request go from “someone has an idea” to “engineering is building it”? Is there a system? Is there a business case? Does someone with context decide what matters — or does the loudest voice win?

Most orgs skip this part. They jump straight to execution frameworks and quarterly planning without ever defining how work enters the pipeline in the first place.

The unsexy truth: a clear intake process — where requests are prioritized against defined business objectives, not gut feelings — does more for shipping velocity than any reorg, new tool, or methodology ever will.

Process isn't the enemy of speed. Chaos is.

The Trap of Being Good at Your Job

Useful gets you in the building. Intentional gets you where you want to go.

Nobody talks about the trap of being good at your job.

I've always been the person who solves problems and relieves pressure in a room. That's how I got into rooms in the first place. But once people realize you're valuable, you get invited to everything. Every meeting, every thread, every fire drill. And before you know it, your calendar owns you and you haven't built anything in weeks.

This is where most careers stall. Not from a lack of skill, but a lack of boundaries. The thing that got you in the door becomes the thing that keeps you stuck once you're inside.

The shift I'm working on is moving from "how do I get in the room" to "is this room worth my time." That means saying no, getting told no, and protecting my capacity the same way I'd protect a product roadmap — against every well-intentioned distraction.

Being useful gets you in the building. Being intentional gets you where you actually want to go.

Leadership: Shield or Funnel

The environment determines the output. The team didn't change. The conditions did.

Product organizations that ship and ones that just spin have one difference: whether leadership absorbs pressure or passes it down.

McKinsey's Product Management Index found fewer than half of PMs feel prepared to play the roles expected of them. Only 35% have clarity on what it takes to advance. But the stat no survey captures is how many PMs were sold a vision in the interview that never materialized. You get hired to build and ship product. Own a roadmap. Work closely with engineering. Drive strategy. Then you show up and the real job is managing legacy debt, dragging a half-dead product up a hill nobody internally believes in, or becoming a buffer between anxious executives and confused engineers. Product manager to project janitor, and nobody told you the switch happened.

That bait-and-switch is more common than anyone wants to admit, and it's a leadership problem.

Everything breaks when leadership pushes stress downstream instead of processing it into clarity. New urgent meeting. New ask with no context. Priorities shift with no explanation. The team absorbs the chaos and gets blamed when nothing ships.

It doesn't stop at the PM. When PMs are buried in reactive work, engineers lose clear requirements and build against a moving target. Sprints fill with fire drills instead of roadmap items. Technical debt compounds because nobody has room to address it.

Good product leadership means being the filter between organizational noise and your team's ability to execute. It means translating pressure into clear priorities instead of forwarding the anxiety. It means building systems so work enters the pipeline through defined business objectives, not whoever panicked last.

The best leaders I've worked with had one thing in common: their teams rarely felt the chaos above them. Not because there wasn't any, but because leadership absorbed it and translated pressure into direction.

The worst did the opposite. Megaphones for every fire drill. And the PMs underneath them weren't managing products. They were managing their boss's emotions.

The environment determines the output. Put a great PM and great engineers in a dysfunctional org and they'll look average. Put those same people somewhere with clear ownership, real trust, and

leadership that shields instead of funnels, and they'll build something meaningful. The team didn't change. The conditions did.

Product leadership isn't about having all the answers. It's about creating the conditions where talented people can do what you hired them to do.

ESSAY 05 OF 10

Stop Redesigning the Showcase. Fix the Product.

What the NBA taught me about product lip service

I played basketball my whole life — D1, overseas in China and Spain. The NBA has a product problem, and it's not the All-Star Game.

The All-Star Game is the symptom. Every year they roll out a new format — East vs. West, captain's draft, mini tournament, USA vs. World — hoping the packaging fixes the product. It doesn't.

The real problem: 82 games is too many. Stars rest through marquee matchups. The regular season barely matters. Timeouts and commercials turn a 48-minute game into a 3-hour broadcast. The product is bloated.

The fix is obvious. Shorten the season. Cut the timeouts. Make every game matter. But that means fewer tickets, fewer broadcasts, less short-term revenue. No owner wants that trade.

So they redecorate the All-Star Weekend instead and call it progress.

Sound familiar? Every product org does this. The product is bloated, the users are disengaged, and leadership knows it. But instead of cutting what doesn't work, they rebrand the process, reorganize the team, launch a new initiative. Anything that looks like change without actually risking anything.

Stop redesigning the showcase. Fix the product.

The Spinner vs. The Narration

Communication maturity is knowing when to stop communicating

The most mature product teams aren't asking how to communicate more. They're asking when to stop.

Think about how AI tools work now. Claude doesn't just process in silence — it tells you exactly what it's doing. "Extracting content. Cleaning the HTML. Cross-referencing sources." Visible progress. You know it's working.

But now the next question is emerging: do I actually need all of that?

Sometimes the narration becomes noise. You just want the output.

That tension — too little communication vs. too much — is one of the most sophisticated problems a product team can have.

Most teams will never get there.

They're still in the whack-a-mole phase. Ten requests in five different channels. No triage. No visibility into what's happening or why. Customers waiting in silence while the team is buried.

The goal isn't to narrate everything. The goal is to know your product, your team, and your customer well enough to deliver exactly the right signal at the right moment.

That takes depth most orgs aren't even close to.

I Enjoy Working

We're not rejecting work. We're rejecting places where trust never existed.

I enjoy working.

Solving a real problem with people I like, building something cool — that feels good. That gives me purpose and fuels the rest of my life.

We spend so much of our lives working. I've been iterating on my own approach for decades trying to find the right balance.

Here's what I've learned: the great PMs, the great founders, the people who build things worth building — they embrace contradictions. They know which fires are worth fighting. They have such a strong sense of self that prioritization comes naturally.

Transcending “the grind” starts with knowing the people around you well enough to stop assuming the worst. Not reading every email as an attack. Not treating every disagreement as a threat.

When you truly know someone — when there's real trust in the room — you stop wasting energy on defense and start spending it on the work.

That's what makes an environment worth showing up to: the feeling that the people around you are on your side.

Most of us aren't rejecting work. We're rejecting places where that feeling never existed.

We don't have to choose between our sanity and our careers. We do have to be intentional about what we build — and who we build it with.

Desperation is a Bad Negotiator

Clarity is the only thing that keeps you from trading one bad situation for another

Desperation is a bad negotiator.

In dating, in your career — it doesn't matter. When you need something too badly, you stop evaluating clearly. Every option looks better than it is. Every red flag gets explained away.

The fix isn't more options. It's clarity. And clarity doesn't come from looking harder — it comes from stopping.

Three questions worth sitting with regardless of where you are: If everything changed tomorrow, what would you refuse to compromise on? What have you consistently wanted across every role, every city, every chapter? What are you tolerating that you said you never would?

But what if you're already in it? Already desperate, already compromised?

You build leverage. Not by escaping — by making yourself harder to ignore. You do the work in front of you well enough that you have options. You invest in something outside the situation that reminds you who you are. You stop making the thing you need the only thing you're focused on.

Desperation shrinks when you have somewhere else to put your energy.

The answers don't just help you find the next thing. They help you stop chasing the wrong one.

Your Anxiety is Not Your Team's Emergency

On fake transformations and the leaders who fund them

"We're becoming product-led."

Sure you are.

You've got sprint ceremonies and a roadmap in Jira. Meetings about meetings. Feedback loops that go nowhere. PMs spending more time managing up than building anything.

That's not product-led. That's the appearance of process as a substitute for actual decision-making.

The best managers I've had did the opposite. They absorbed the chaos from above so it never reached me. When I was spiraling, they brought my anxiety down instead of adding to it. They were present before things went wrong — not just when the pressure hit.

That's the job. Not redistributing stress. Containing it.

The manager who only shows up when something's on fire isn't engaged. They're just running a different kind of anxiety response. And their team knows the difference.

Real transformation requires leaders who make calls instead of scheduling alignment. Who give their people context and cover — not pressure campaigns. Who are consistent, not just available in a crisis.

No retro fixes that. No org chart redesign fixes that.

Your anxiety is not your team's emergency.

*“The environment determines the output.
The team didn’t change. The conditions did.”*

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